Rasha Thadani

All of 19, Rasha, daughter of Raveena Tandon, has already made heads turn with her dancing skills in 'Uyi Amma', a song that has amassed 97 million views on YouTube and counting, and scored a deal with Nykaa



class and we were bored so we literally watched whatever was playing," recalls Junaid. It would stoke a desire to study acting which he did for two years at the American Academy of Dramatic Arts in New York followed by a year with its repertory company. Starting out on stage in 2017, which he continues to do to date, Junaid assisted Rajkumar Hirani on *PK* (2014) and then auditioned for *Laal Singh Chadha* (2022). He didn't land the part, and it eventually went to his father. He'd bag the lead role in YRF's *Maharaj* (2024) and then waited for its release as Covid-19 played spoilsport.

Dancing with the Star Kids

Wariness towards star kids is not deterring the likes of Karan Johar who took to Instagram to announce that his banner, Dharma, is geared up for a "new chapter" as it gives a break to eight actors in 2025, among them, Saif's son Ibrahim, who assisted Johar on his last, *Rocky aur Rani Kii Prem Kahaani* (2023). "Films are in their blood, their genes, and their passion," said Johar of Saif, Amrita Singh and Sara. "We make way for a new wave of talent, one I cannot wait for the world to see." The roster of rookies also includes Shanaya, who joins friends Ananya and Suhana for a career in showbusiness. Johar is conscious of the public image he has of being an enabler of "nepo babies", an unflattering term used to categorise newcomers who have a leg-up because they come from film families. "Some journeys are perceived as privileged, some are also given the tag of lineage benefit... and all of that is true," he wrote on Instagram, "but, in you, Shanaya I have only seen a girl who dreamt of nothing but being a pure artist and facing the camera only when you had put in immense hard work and passion."

At the Netflix event, Ibrahim danced and didn't utter a word, choosing instead to pose for the shutterbugs, who called him "Iggy" with a sense of familiarity. The challenge for Bollywood's neophytes is combating overexposure. Social media has both robbed them of mystique and curiosity among audiences. The paparazzi culture means that most of them are being tracked outside their homes, en route to the gym or the airport. "Stars were not accessible once upon a time. That star power is not there," adds Somaya. "You are seeing them on Insta every day and there's so much pressure on appearance."

As a result, the more-is-less approach is backfiring on some. Pahariya, for instance, found himself at the receiving end of much ire for his incessant appearances and privileged background after his film's release. So relentless was the troll army that the actor asked a news channel if he should kill himself and be reborn in another family. "All I can do is work with pure dedication so that everyone thinks I deserve to be in this industry," he said.

The new batch of actors may have their entry sorted, but handling the criticism, pressure and expectations that comes with carrying their illustrious surnames is anything but easy. "Pressure will always be there," says Khushi. "It's not like Janhvi and I are trying to reach her [Sridevi's] level, be her and emulate her. I won't be able to match up to that. We both are our own people and we should continue on our own paths."

Junaid doesn't let the burden of legacy faze him. "I never felt it. I don't think I need to because Papa is very much around and still doing lots of work. In fact, he will have a film come out soon after mine," he says. Their parents may have owned Bollywood at one point, but to inherit it, they'll need much more than a famous surname. ■